

SPOILER-FREE PREVIEW

A family story under pressure.

Read an opening scene and one genuine exhibit from the expanded narrative edition. This preview contains no solution or hidden identity disclosure.

Inside the complete game: a sustained character story, an archive of inspectable records, working pages, progressive hints, an evidence-cited solution, and an expanded aftermath.

Play alone or investigate together. Every required clue is in the supplied papers. Print in grayscale or use the PDF bookmarks and catalog. No host or outside research is needed.

Player file: 25 pages. Preview pages are selected excerpts; their archive and story labels match the full edition.

THE STORY CONTINUES

The keys on Ruth's desk

Before the opening brief

Ruth Fenwick put the mill keys on a folded cloth. She had discovered that leaving them in sight made people speak to the keys instead of to her. Putting them away made people ask where they were. There seemed to be no neutral place for an inheritance.

Nell Mercer arrived with papers she had tried to keep flat. Arthur's papers were already arranged. Clara Whitcomb paused at the doorway until Ruth moved a chair out for her.

"We could have settled the family part ourselves," Arthur said.

Nell sat down. "Then you wouldn't have needed my papers."

He gave her the weary look of a brother being contradicted in company. Ruth saw Nell almost answer it with an apology. Instead she put her packet on the desk.

Clara kept her hands in her lap. She was the person easiest for the others to treat as an intrusion. Ruth asked her to move closer so she could see the will.

"I didn't choose my mother's name to inconvenience anyone," Clara said quietly.

Arthur looked embarrassed. Nell made room on the desk.

Henry Vale had left words that seemed simple until living people began placing themselves inside them. Earliest-born. Surviving. Child. The claimants could all tell stories about what a family ought to recognize. The document required a particular relationship and an order of birth.

"I am not asking which of you needs the property most," Ruth said. "Nor which of you can speak most confidently about it."

"It has to be managed," Arthur said.

"That is a different question."

Nell looked at the keys. She had not been offered the ease of treating the business as a foregone conclusion. Even being asked what she intended to do with it would have meant somebody believed she might have a claim.

Ruth turned the will so everyone could read. "You may dislike the result. I won't ask you to dislike it less. I will ask you to let the papers be checked."

Outside, the town's work went on. Inside, three people waited for an old man's language to determine which of their futures could become real. Ruth kept her hand beside the keys. Not on them. Nobody had yet earned an answer merely by reaching first.

The disputed bequest

Will extract / 17 June 1908

Vale estate papers / instrument 18 / clause IV

I, Henry Vale, of Bellwether, Pennsylvania, direct that my house, my interest in Vale Mill, and the remainder of my estate pass to the eldest child born to my sister Ada who shall be living at my death.

By my sister Ada I mean Ada Vale, daughter of Martin Vale and Eliza Vale, who married Joseph Reed of Bellwether. By eldest I mean earliest born; a deceased child shall be passed over. Neither sex nor present surname shall give preference.

My executor shall establish that person from the family records before releasing the estate. I have been long absent from my sister's household and will not risk an erroneous name in this instrument.

Testator	Henry Vale
Witnesses	Martha Stone; Peter Voss
Death recorded by executor	1 October 1912
Estate file	HV / 1912 / 18

Game rule: apply the clause exactly as written. Its validity is stipulated. No knowledge of inheritance law is needed.

Research note / What does this change? Which record would test it?

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